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What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **A broadening** Middle East conflict sparked stock-market declines from New York to Seoul, with the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow partially recovering from deeper troughs to finish down 0.9%, 1% and 0.8%, respectively. **A1**

◆ **OpenAI CEO Sam Altman** defended his decision to allow the Pentagon to use its tools for classified work, fielding questions from staff about the principles behind the decision. **A2**

◆ **Two of the largest** charities that subsidize medical costs for low- and middle-income Americans merged in one of the biggest combinations in nonprofit healthcare. **A2**

◆ **Verizon has been** scrutinizing hundreds of millions of dollars in spending on sports and music sponsorships as part of its push to cut costs. **B1**

◆ **Target reported its** 13th consecutive quarter of feeble or falling sales and the retailer's new chief executive said he had a remedy for the weakness. **B1**

◆ **Car-parts retailer** AutoZone said winter storms stalled momentum during the recent quarter, resulting in lower-than-expected sales. **B2**

◆ **Schaeffler shares fell** nearly 22% in European trade after the car-parts supplier gave guidance ranges that at their midpoints were weaker than expected. **B3**

◆ **Meta Platforms is** creating a new applied AI engineering organization to help bolster the company's superintelligence efforts. **B3**

◆ **Elliott invested** \$1 billion in Pinterest, which the company will use to accelerate share repurchases **B4**

Worldwide

◆ **The four-day Middle East** conflict widened as Iran stepped up missile and drone attacks in the region and Israel attacked targets in Lebanon. **A1, A5, A7**

◆ **Trump is open** to supporting groups in Iran willing to take up arms to dislodge the regime, U.S. officials said, as he considers options about who should succeed the country's fallen leader. **A5**

◆ **The Justice Department** said it plans to press on with the defense of Trump's executive orders sanctioning law firms, a reversal that came less than 24 hours after it asked to drop the cases. **A3**

◆ **The Justice Department** has withheld thousands of documents from the Epstein files, including FBI documents that detailed a woman's unverified allegations of sexual misconduct against Trump, according to a review by The Wall Street Journal. **A4**

◆ **A jury found the father** of the teenage boy charged with killing four people at a Georgia high school guilty of second-degree murder and involuntary manslaughter. **A3**

◆ **The inspector general** for the Department of Homeland Security said the agency's leaders had "systematically obstructed" its work. **A3**

◆ **The heated Republican** Senate primary in Texas is headed to a runoff between Sen. John Cornyn and state Attorney General Ken Paxton. **A4**

◆ **Democratic lawmakers** are preparing legislation that would break up U.S. meat-packing companies, escalating government efforts to curb record-high beef prices. **A2**

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War Spreads in Mideast, Roils Markets

Fears of stalled growth and inflation amid broader conflict spark selloff

By KRYSTAL HUR

A broadening Middle East conflict sparked stock-market declines from New York to Seoul, with an early spike in oil prices touching off fears about an economic slowdown and a fresh bout of inflation.

The Dow Jones Industrial Average slid more than 1,200 points on Tuesday morning, on pace for its worst day since April, after the conflict threatened to halt access to the Strait of Hormuz, a key maritime corridor for the world's oil supply. European and Asian stocks also fell sharply, as did gold and bitcoin. Treasury yields ticked higher.

By midafternoon trading, the blue-chip index and other major U.S. benchmarks had found their footing.

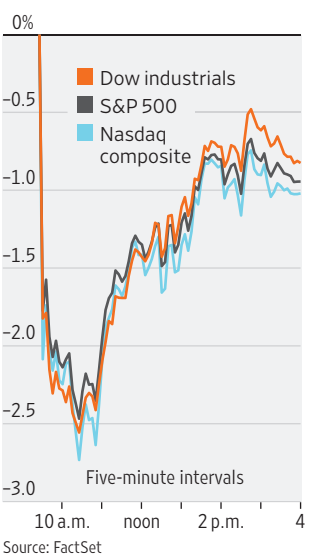
President Trump wrote in a social-media post that he had ordered the U.S. International Development Finance Corp. to provide insurance and guarantees to maritime trade in the Persian Gulf, and he offered Naval escorts to tankers if necessary.

The Dow fell for a third-straight session, closing Tuesday down 0.8%, or around 404 points. Oil prices steadied, with U.S. crude futures ending the session 4.7% higher at \$74.56 a barrel.

The selloff continued in Asia early Wednesday. Japan's Nikkei 225 was down 3.9% at the midday break in Tokyo, while

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Index performance Tuesday



Source: FactSet



Smoke poured from near the U.S. consulate in Dubai in the United Arab Emirates, top, after an Iranian drone attack Tuesday. Above, the aftermath of an Israeli strike in Beirut's suburbs.

Gulf's Post-Oil Economic Pivot at Risk

By GEORGI KANTCHEV

The Persian Gulf's costly gamble to build a post-oil future is now facing trial by combat as war rages.

After years—and hundreds of billions of dollars—spent transforming the region into a nexus for artificial intelligence, tourism and logistics, those aspirations are now under fire as Iranian strikes pound the United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia and neighboring states.

Amazon said early Tuesday it expected extended service interruptions following damage from drone attacks on three data centers in the region. The outages, which have led to users in the Gulf reporting banking app glitches, compound what has quickly become the most severe business disruption the Middle East has faced since the pandemic—and one that threatens to leave even more enduring consequences.

Across the region, thousands of flights have been grounded in some of the world's busiest airports, shipping disruptions have severed key trade and energy lifelines, and stock markets have plunged. Thousands of stranded tourists are scrambling to evacuate on the few flights that are going out after smoke from blazing luxury hotels and other damaged sites streaked the glitzy Dubai skyline.

"Iran's strikes on the Gulf economies have punctured the perceived security and stability of the region," said Jason Tuvey, deputy chief emerging markets economist at Capital Economics. "This will lead to disruptions to non-oil activity in the near term and, if the attacks persist, could also threaten investment and diversification efforts over the longer term."

Beyond the immediate

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Trump's Case for War in Iran Faces Growing Scrutiny

WASHINGTON—The Trump administration, in pressing its case for war with Iran, has made a number of accusations about the regime's threats to its neighbors, U.S. troops, and even the American homeland itself.

However, U.S. officials and lawmakers with access to classified information, along with experts who have spent their careers poring over public data

and government reports, said the administration's assertions are incomplete, unsubstantiated, or flat-out wrong.

And questions will only intensify as administration officials brief Congress this week.

"The administration has been inconsistent and often inaccurate in explaining why we are at war, what we are trying to achieve and how we

intend to achieve it," said Michael Singh, who handled the Middle East portfolio in Republican George W. Bush's White House. "I don't think the administration has sought to mislead, but one does get

the sense that they are building the aircraft midflight."

President Trump said Tuesday in the Oval Office that he believed Iran was "going to attack first," as he discussed his reason for striking Iran.

"I didn't want that to happen," he said. Asked about the notion that Israel's plans to attack Iran might have forced Trump's hand, the president

responded: "No. I might have forced Israel's hand."

That perspective developed during negotiations with Tehran, he said.

"We were having negotiations with these lunatics," he said, referring to Iran. "It was my opinion that they were going to attack first."

Meanwhile some senior ad-

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Iran Trump weighs backing militias. A5	Capital Account The path from war to oil security. A6	Casualties Troops killed in Kuwait weren't warned of attack. A7	Washington Strikes reflect go-it-alone approach to the world. A7	Streetwise In a day of wild market moves, oil is a haven. B12
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Teacup Pigs Don't Exist. They Found Out the Hard Way.

* * *

Animal lovers are discovering that in the livestock world, 'mini' is a relative term

By AMIRA MCKEE

Teacup. Pixie. Itty-bitty. Micro. Pocket-size.

When Jessica Moul went scrolling through Craigslist for a new family pet, she knew she wanted an itty-bitty pig.

Beguiled by photos of teensy piglets, she chose the runt of the litter—a tiny, shivering nugget for \$350. The seller promised the "teacup" pig would top out at 40 pounds and sent her on her way.

But when Moul introduced her new companion to an online pig-owner group, she got a quick education.

"Everybody's laughing at

me," she recalled. "They're like, 'There's no such thing, lady.'"

Today, that piglet is Tucker—a 200-pound porker who has outgrown the family bathroom, shredded a couch and required the installation of heavy-duty horse panels to keep him from escaping the yard of his Arizona home.

Plenty of people have fallen for the promise of a forever-small pig. Around the pandemic, when Americans were homebound and scrolling for companionship, interest in unconventional pets picked up. Pigs can keep growing for up to five years, and veterinari-

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INSIDE



SPORTS
The dirt track racer backed by Michael Jordan who's conquering NASCAR. **A16**

PROPERTY REPORT
Los Angeles's notorious trio of graffiti-covered towers finally finds a buyer. **B6**

Ski Town's Dispute Goes Downhill Fast

Telluride is locked in a fight with the eccentric owner of its luxury resort

By JIM CARLTON

TELLURIDE, Colo.—On a snowy March evening last year, a local official stepped to the microphone to declare that this winter ski paradise was in crisis. He singled out one man.

"Chuck is failing us all," said Paul Wisor, grim-faced and wearing a blue puffer jacket, as he stood before the council and a packed room of residents. They gave him a standing ovation.

"Chuck" was Chuck Horning, longtime owner of the Telluride Ski & Golf resort.

While many ski towns have spent years mourning the rise of corporate conglomerates swallowing mom-and-pop owners, a growing faction in Telluride was pushing in the opposite direction. They wanted to oust Horning, one of the last independent operators of a major Western ski resort.

Detractors argued Horning had allowed the resort to lag behind rivals like Vail and Jackson Hole.

"Time to chuck Chuck," councilman Dan Enright posted on social media. "Tel-

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